Out of this period, even with an infrastructure of state-funded programs, Berlin gained the distinction of being both a wasteland of historical memory and an artists' dream destination, pushing the outer limits of formal circuits of cultural exchange. Artists responded to the city's aesthetic influence and physical landscapes and interiors. They made frequent trips across somewhat relaxed borders to East Berlin, and powerfully, the experience of living near the Wall, the ritual of living in the city, spurred American critical thinkers and cultural producers to seek West Berlin as a personal refuge, a pressure cooker, or both. Habitual West Berlin denizen Iggy Pop, who recorded albums with David Bowie in the abandoned-Nazi-ballroom-turned-recording-studio Hansa at the Berlin Wall, near Potsdamer Platz, recalled 1970s Berlin as "a city you could go to get lost in, or be forgotten and still get something done. A good and dangerous place for lunatics and the artistically minded."[20] The view from Hansa inspired Bowie's "Heroes," an anthem spotlighting insistent lovers who embrace at the Wall despite the risk and violence that surround them. The Wall's looming condition elicited numerous creative responses provoked by its evolving form, footprint, and shifting geopolitical realities.

In November 1970, performance artist Allan Kaprow visited West Berlin on a DAAD grant to pursue a site-specific project along the border. In conjunction with the Rene Block Galerie, Kaprow carried out a performance on Köthener Strasse in Kreuzberg titled *Sweet Wall*. Known for his "happenings" in other cities in which banal activities with minimal staging became vehicles for performance art, Kaprow referred to this as an "activity" in an advertised flyer. With a small group of collaborators and a location of an empty lot near the border wall, Kaprow fashioned a wall of cinder blocks held together with bread and jam as its mortar. Soon after constructing this analogous wall, the group toppled its own creation. *Sweet Wall* was neither a work of resolute mirroring nor fully disconnected from the idea of playfully and feasibly commandeering the physicality of the wall. Kaprow reflected on this project, stating, "As a parody, *Sweet Wall* was about an idea of a wall. The Berlin Wall was an idea, too: it summed up in one medieval image the ideological division of Europe. … Like the wall with its bread and jam, symbols could be produced and erased at will. The participants could speculate on the practical value of such freedom, to themselves and others. That was its sweetness and irony."[21]